tiebreaker

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31339145.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
other characters make an appearance but are not central, 5+1 Things, POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), sequences 1 to 5 cover scenes from the show, in order:, s1e9: No Princess Left Behind, s1e11: Promise, s2e5: White Out, s3e3: Once Upon A Time In The Waste, s3e4: Moment of Truth, and then for the +1, Post-Canon, technically number 5 isn't catra wielding the sword but, close enough, Angst with a Happy Ending, technically? angst with a sharp turn into not-angst-at-all?, catra's having a bad time but it gets better, +1 is basically a post-canon fluff one shot, it got away from me a bit, this whole thing is mostly an excuse to give catra a sword

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2021-05-16 Words: 8,462 Chapters: 1/1

tiebreaker

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31339145.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
other characters make an appearance but are not central, 5+1 Things, POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), sequences 1 to 5 cover scenes from the show, in order:, s1e9: No Princess Left Behind, s1e11: Promise, s2e5: White Out, s3e3: Once Upon A Time In The Waste, s3e4: Moment of Truth, and then for the +1, Post-Canon, technically number 5 isn't catra wielding the sword but, close enough, Angst with a Happy Ending, technically? angst with a sharp turn into not-angst-at-all?, catra's having a bad time but it gets better, +1 is basically a post-canon fluff one shot, it got away from me a bit, this whole thing is mostly an excuse to give catra a sword

Language:
English

Stats:

Published: 2021-05-16 Words: 8,462 Chapters: 1/1

tiebreaker

by ariesnoctua (SleepyMaddy)

Summary

5 times Catra tried to use the sword of protection to win, and one time she succeeded (sort of)

or: Catra, with Adora's sword

Notes

characterization and plot analysis brain: the sword represents so many things, and notably the idea of control, like the control the first ones exerted over she-ra; for catra, that has to strike home, because while the sword is what took adora away from her in the first place, it's also a key to get control back and control is one of the things she's always been pursuing—

wlw brain: hehe girl with sword hot

See the end of the work for more notes

One

The tip of the sword digs into the metal wall as she drags it. The resulting screech *hurts*, the vibrations traveling up her arm and digging into her skull like an icepick, but she doesn't let up. Pain is good –it keeps you sharp. It's the one useful thing the Horde's taught her.

The tip catches slightly on an indent in the wall, but she tugs and it keeps going, keeps digging the gouge into the wall. Idly, she wonders if magical swords can get damaged. If they can, this'll definitely do the trick; she pictures tiny fragments of the shiny blade flaking off, minuscule cracks forming into its perfect surface.

She *hopes* magical swords can get damaged.

Adora and the princess are just *standing* there. The door beyond them is shut tight, thanks to the alarms Adora triggered, so their options are kinda limited, but still. They're not making any move to hide, or to find another way out.

Then again, they're not exactly in top shape. The princess is a wreck, her sparkly dress all but torn to shreds, with scratches and cuts all over her. Adora's not quite as bad, but her shoulders are slumped, and there's a slightly dazed look in her eyes. It's barely anything anyone would notice, but Catra knows her well enough to know what it means; that she simply doesn't have the energy to hide how badly she's hurt.

Yeah. That's what Shadow Weaver's spells will do to you. Catra's intimately familiar.

For all her exhaustion, Adora's gaze sharpens when she realizes Catra's here. She takes a step forward in front of her friend, and if she wasn't so pissed, Catra would roll her eyes. Always the hero. Once upon a time, *she'*d have been the one Adora stepped forward to protect. Catra had never been able to decide whether the accompanying pang in her own chest meant she hated it or loved it.

Still, this is ridiculous. At this point, a strong *breeze* could knock Adora down, and Catra's armed.

She stops a few feet away, and stares.

And then she lifts the sword, leveling the annoyingly-sharp point at Adora.

She could do it. It'd be ridiculously easy. And it'd solve all her problems, presumably –Shadow Weaver wouldn't be *able* to choose Adora if she wasn't around to be chosen anymore.

Now that Adora is back, there is no need for you there.

The blade doesn't waver.

Neither does Adora's gaze as she stares at her.

She could do it. She *could*.

The alarms around them blare. In a few minutes, it won't matter what Catra does; the place will be swarmed with guards, and Adora will be taken in. Shadow Weaver will finish the job, Adora will take back her place, and Catra will be nothing again.

She sees it, for one moment –Adora, straight-backed and determined, but with a blank gaze and a red haze, and Shadow Weaver's hand on her shoulder.

Catra finds she can't quite breathe right.

Slowly, she releases her grip, letting the weight of the blade spin the sword around until she's offering the hilt to Adora.

The hard look in the blue eyes melts away, surprise flickering in them instead. "What are you doing?"

"Take it."

Adora's always been so goddamn transparent. Catra can see every single emotion cross her face, can almost *hear* her thought

process. When it settles on a tentative hope, she grits her teeth and looks away. “This is *not* because I like you.”

The silence holds for a second, as Adora faces the same choice she had, all those weeks ago. The sword, or home. The sword, or her old life.

The sword, or Catra.

Slowly, almost gently, she reaches an arm out and wraps her hand around the hilt. Catra lets go immediately, like the metal’s burnt her.

Yeah. That’s how that choice always goes.

“Catra, I–“

She’s not interested. “Just… get out of here.”

Resolve hardens Adora’s expression again, and she lifts her arm, sword pointed up. “For the honor… of Grayskull!”

Catra doesn’t look away, only flinching slightly when the light turns blinding. She forces herself to look, hoping the reality will finally sink in, for good.

This is what Adora chooses, what she will *always* choose.

She watches as her friend vanishes, and wills herself to see the tall, glowing woman standing in her place as something alien and threatening. It should be easy, when she slashes the heavy metal door in two with an almost effortless swipe of her sword.

But all she sees is Adora.

She doesn’t hang around to watch her leave –she’s had enough of that already.

Two

Catra fucking *hates* magic.

She hates everything about it. She hates how glowy it is, hates how it makes everything fucking *twinkle* and shift and glitter. And she *hates* how it can get into her head.

That's nothing new, really. After all, it's what Shadow Weaver's used hers to do since Catra was born. But no matter how pastel and glittery *this* magic is, Catra can see the truth: it's just as wrong, just as messed up as Shadow Weaver's dark wisps. How Adora can't see that is beyond her.

Then again, she thinks as she tears into the last remaining spiders with an energy that is uncomfortably close to desperation, how would Adora know? It's not like she ever experienced it firsthand.

Or like she cared when Catra did.

She screams as she rips wires from the head of the spider she's perched on. Frustration and rage mingle and burn behind her eyes, but they never, *never* drown out the truth.

You look out for me, I look out for you.

The spider collapses to the floor and she jumps off, onto the last one, twisting out of the way of a deadly sharp leg swatting at the air.

Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.

The spider rears back when Catra lands, nearly shaking her off, but she digs her claws in and *tears*. Sparks go up, singeing against her hands and arms, but she doesn't notice. She tears gashes into the metal, claws turning everything to shreds under her hands.

She hung onto those words for years. Through every endless training drill, through every miserable punishment, through every

demeaning telling-off –she stayed, because that was the *deal*. None of it mattered, because they were *together*, and eventually, their time would come, and they'd be calling the shots.

And Adora *left*.

The burn in her eyes turns to a scalding blur as it spills over, and with one last rage-filled scream, she finishes the robot off, plunging her hand into its head, grabbing, and *pulling*. It hurts – she's pretty sure she's bleeding, cuts on burnt skin making her want to hiss, but she takes the pain and *holds*, lets it clear her head as she jumps away from the spider. She lands a way away, watching silently as the robot sparks and shudders, before falling inert.

Adora left. Adora never cared. Odds are, she doesn't even remember that day, much less the words themselves. Adora's always been nice after all; that's all it was. A few consoling words, thrown without a care, that Catra was stupid enough, *weak* enough to take to heart.

And why would she care? It's not like Adora's ever needed *her*. That's one thing all these memories have made abundantly clear.

"Catra?"

The voice is faint, coming from the large room ahead, but at the sound, all of Catra's anger ices over into something that's close enough to calm. Slowly, almost leisurely, she walks in that direction.

Adora's never needed her; that's fine. Catra doesn't need her either.

Whatever she might have believed, what *anyone* might have thought… She never has.

The room ahead is cavernous, and made even more so by the way the floor gives way to a gaping precipice after barely a few feet. Something shiny catches Catra's eye, and she lifts an

eyebrow as she recognizes Adora's sword, lying abandoned. Her name comes again, clearly from the chasm this time, but she takes her time picking the weapon up before making her way to the edge.

Adora's clinging to some spider webbing. It's the only thing stopping her from tumbling into the endless dark below. Pretty precarious position to be in, but her face lights up when she sees Catra.

The cold hardens in her veins, like metal left outside overnight in the middle of winter. Casually, she runs a finger along the edge of the blade. "Hey, Adora."

Adora's a bit too far down for Catra to be able to read her expression properly, but her voice wavers a little when she speaks again. "Catra, help me, please…"

She forces her gaze on the sword, away from her. It's *pretty*, objectively. All gold and glowy, with intricate engravings. The blade is pristine –no trace of damage. She's not really surprised. "This thing wouldn't work for me if I tried, would it? It only works for *you*. Then again, you're special. That's what Shadow Weaver always said."

"Catra, what are you doing?" Catra can see it finally clicking in her head that this is not going to go the way she thought it would. It makes sense that it'd take that long, though; it's not like Adora's used to that.

"Ah, you know? It all makes sense now. You've always been the one holding me back. You wanted me to think I needed you. You wanted me to feel *weak*. Every hero needs a *sidekick*, right?" The words *hurt*, but she lets them. She's spent so much time hiding from the truth –it's only fair that it hurts as it comes out.

Adora's voice is edging into desperation now. It's probably got to do with the way the webbing is starting to fall apart. "No, Catra, that's not how it was–"

A horrible, childish part of Catra wants to believe her. She wants her to be telling the truth, really; that's all she's ever wanted.

But she's wasted enough time already. She is *done*. It's time for her to stop being so weak, time to take control back.

She laughs, sharp and humorless and self-deprecating, as she allows herself one bit of honesty. "The sad thing is, I've spent *all* this *time* hoping you'd come back to the Horde, when really you leaving was the best thing that *ever* happened to me." She tilts her head and lowers the blade of the sword to the webbing. If it's going to stay sharp through everything, might as well use it for something. "I am so much *stronger* than *anyone* ever thought."

The *clack* of the webbing snapping echoes, covered only by Adora's shout as she loses one grip. Catra doesn't stop, snapping one strand at a time, picturing everyone who ever underestimated her, feeling them snap and give away under the metal.

One strand for Shadow Weaver. One for their training instructors. One for the other cadets. One for Hordak.

"I wonder what I could have been, if I'd gotten rid of you sooner."

Clack. One for Catra.

Adora shrieks as she falls, only barely catching herself on a stray handhold sticking out of the cliff's face. "I-I'm sorry! I never meant to make you feel like you were second best! Please, don't do this!"

The hesitation comes again, but it's easier to ignore now. She eyes the sword one more time, before tossing it into the dark. It's not *hers*, and she doesn't need it anyway. It clangs against the walls, down, down, down, swallowed by the dark. As if in response, the lights of the room flicker.

"Bye, Adora. I really am going to miss you." She's not lying, not really, but she'll work on it. She's stronger than even she ever

knew, and now? Without anything to hold her back, to make her *weak*? She'll be stronger than ever.

Adora calls after her. Adora calls after her, again, and again, desperate and choking, but Catra doesn't slow down as she walks away. She'll be fine –this place is designed for her, for She-Ra. There's no way it'll actually hurt her. Adora's way too *special* for that.

As *always,* Adora doesn't need her.

And so, Catra leaves.

Three

For the first time since they made it to this stupid place, Catra doesn't mind the cold.

How could she? She's fucking *elated*. Hell, she'd have spent *months* in this miserable weather if it'd meant that kind of result. She swings the red, veiny sword up, resting the flat of the blade on her shoulder as she makes her way through the base corridors.

When Hordak had assigned her out there, she'd gritted her teeth to resist the urge to protest. With Shadow Weaver out of the picture, she *finally* had a chance to prove herself, but that would take time. As much as she'd have preferred to be out on the front lines and making decisions that actually *changed* things, this was how the Horde worked. She'd have to prove herself, and this would be her chance to do it –snow storms and all. She'd figured bringing back some First Ones tech would be a good start.

But *this*? She swallows down a satisfied cackle as she remembers Adora passed out in the lab. This is beyond perfect. Hordak sends her away to the middle of fucking nowhere, and she comes back with the *Rebellion's hero*. Not only that, with the means to turn

said hero *against them*. Even if She-Ra wasn't half as brutally efficient as she is, the morale hit *alone* would make this worth it.

But as it happens, she is. Absently, Catra pauses and tentatively rotates her ankle. There's a faint, pulsing ring of pain there, where She-Ra grabbed her mid-jump, before slamming her into the ground. Adora had always been strong, and even more so as her glowier persona, but Catra had never seen the kind of unnatural strength she'd displayed earlier. Whatever that virus does, it clearly doesn't do anything to weaken her. Catra's pretty sure that she could have torn through an *army*, in that state.

Eh. They'll just have to be careful to nudge her in the right direction when setting her loose. Clearly, allegiances don't mean much to her when infected. Only whoever is nearest.

If you'd told her that even an hour ago, she'd have laughed in your face. That was Adora's whole thing, after all, *caring*. Adora *cares*, and that's why it's so easy to get to her. She doesn't have the strength to do what needs to be done. Hell, she'd thrown it in Adora's face during their fight earlier –*you'd never have the guts*.

And she was right, of course she was. Adora might have left the Horde behind, might have tried to become a completely different person, but Catra *knows* her. Yeah, maybe now she can become eight feet tall. Yeah, maybe she can turn her back on everything she grew up believing. But finishing Catra off? *That* she'll never be able to do. Her hero complex alone wouldn't let her.

With that virus, though… A twinge of unease makes itself known in her chest, before she manages to smother it. Whenever she looks at She-Ra, all Catra sees is Adora. Shinier, yes, and annoyingly taller, but Adora. But out there, for one second… It was something else. Angry, powerful, and completely, utterly foreign.

For one second, staring up at her as she raised her sword, Catra had been *afraid*.

A loud *clang* echoes somewhere behind her and she jumps, swiveling around. She stands poised, ready to strike, but nothing comes beyond the howl of the wind.

After a few more tense seconds, she resumes walking. The sooner she finds the source of the alarm, the sooner they can get the hell out of here.

It doesn't matter, whether it's Adora or not when she's She-Ra. All that matters is that with this virus, she won't hesitate. She'll tear through the Rebellion like paper, and do the Horde's work for them. Hordak will have to acknowledge Catra's success, she'll be put in charge, and, best of all, Adora will be here to *watch*.

As long as Catra keeps a hold of this sword, Adora isn't going anywhere. She'll get to see just how well Catra's doing for herself. She'll watch as Catra gets the recognition she always deserved but never got, because it was always all for Adora, Adora, *Adora*. As long as Catra has this sword? She's *winning*.

She can't help but think back to their conversation outside. Well, conversation is a big word for it, considering Adora had been passed out, but still. Catra had gloated, yeah, so fucking *sue her*. This was a victory she'd been working towards for a long time.

That little twinge shows up again, at the memory of how pale and unresponsive Adora'd been. Not enough to spoil her victory… but just enough to sour it a little bit.

She knows what the virus does to She-Ra, clearly, but the twinge tugs harder when Catra realizes she isn't quite sure what it does to *Adora*. For all she knows, her former friend will just alternate between murderous rage and passed out.

That… wouldn't be quite as satisfying as planned.

She tamps down on the feeling, a bit more viciously. It was the shock, that's all. Or the cold, maybe. After all, Adora hadn't even been wearing a *coat*, just her stupid red jacket, even though it was way below freezing.

An ominous creak startles her out of her thoughts. She reflexively lifts her arm, aiming the sword towards the sound, only to jump back with a shriek when something *slams* into the metal ceiling, denting it. The lights flicker.

She grits her teeth, reaffirming her grip on the hilt and stamping out the last of the unease in the same breath, before turning back towards the lab. She doesn't care what is out there. So long as she has this sword, she is *winning*, and she is not letting *anything* –be it Sparkles, the stupid cold, or the blasted First Ones *themselves*– take that away from her.

Four

Catra's gotta admit, this is not the way she thought today would go.

But for once, that's a *good* thing. Instead of a plan going wrong because of stupid rebels, or her achievements getting swept aside like they're nothing, everything is falling into place.

She smirks to herself as she lets herself relax a bit more in the large, throne-like chair. It's uncomfortable as hell, the hard metal of the arm rest digging into her back, but that's not the point. It gives her a perfect vantage point to watch as the gang she took over in a day –in a *day!*– cheer and go through their loot.

Sure, there's probably some tech that could be of use in here, and maybe she should tell them to lay off, but eh… She runs a finger along the edge of the blade in her lap and sighs contentedly. Nothing in that rotting old ship can beat what she already has anyway.

More whooping and happy exclamations go up, and eventually turn into cheers and toasts. She'd never heard the word "party" before everyone started calling for one, but honestly? She could get used to this.

Still, she's not Hordak –she knows to give credit where credit is due. After accepting her new underlings' praise with a gracious smile, she starts a cheer for Scorpia. As it happens, watching the woman blush and try to wave away the praise when everyone takes up the chant is its own brand of fun. A warmer, easier kind than what she's gotten used to, these past few years.

Catra feels *good*, is the idea. So good, in fact, that she's bursting with it. She launches out of her chair, dragging Scorpia along as she all but fucking *skips* out of the room, needing the movement. Even knowing Adora's friends got away doesn't put a damper on her mood as she lists everything that's going right.

Because this is it: Hordak sent her to die out here, and instead, she came up with the solution to *all his problems*. He'll have no choice but to acknowledge it, this time. What other option would he have, when she's delivering him the *key to the planet*? And with She-Ra as extra, free of charge.

Yeah, she's feeling *good*.

"Or, you know, counterpoint, we don't go back at all."

The words crash through her jubilation, but don't register right away. She blinks up at Scorpia in confusion. "What? Why wouldn't we go back?"

Scorpia looks uneasy, but she still continues. "Uh… Because you hate it there?"

"I don't." The answer is automatic, but, well. She doesn't. Of course she doesn't.

Except Scorpia continues talking. She continues talking and as she talks, of how this is the happiest she's ever seen Catra, of how

this is the first time she's seen Catra happy *at all*, the certainty… wavers.

Catra clutches the sword to her chest and looks down, the weight of the metal a reminder –of her victory, or of what she sacrificed for it, she's not sure.

She never even considered the option of staying away. For almost two years now, she's put *everything* into this fight. Every part of herself, always, has been dedicated to the only way out she could imagine: winning. The idea that she could just… walk away? It doesn't click right.

Except that when Scorpia is staring at her like this, hope blatant and words terrifyingly *simple*, it becomes easier to see it. And that? That's scarier than any goddamn thing in this desert.

And so she runs; she stammers an excuse about checking on the prisoner and pretends not to notice the way Scorpia's shoulders fall. She can't *afford* to doubt like this, not when she's so close.

Thankfully, Adora's as predictable as ever, when it comes to being a distraction: Catra's barely inside the hall where they're keeping her that she's already going on about Catra *not doing this* and how *she can't do that*. Catra needles her, mostly because it's so easy. And it's fun, really, it is. It's always fun to watch Adora rant with righteous fury about what *shouldn't happen*, while she's powerless to do anything but watch.

But as fun as it is, Catra can't help but be… distracted. She watches Adora strain against her restraints, towards Catra, like maybe if she says them right, her words will get through to her this time. Usually, it gets on her nerves, but this time she barely notices, too focused on other words.

We don't have *to go back there*.

Forget all of them.

We could, you know. Be happy.

Stars, is she actually considering this? She can't be; this is literally her life's work. And yet…

Adora is *still* talking. "–Light Hope and Mara both said that opening a portal will endanger everyone."

Ugh. Coming here was a mistake. Catra needs to *think*, and she can't do it with Adora droning on.

She stands up, raising the sword into the air and eyeing the way the engravings on the blade reflect the light. "You'll listen to anything weird old holograms tell you, won't you? You should really try to get over that." She's about to walk away, when something else Adora said tugs at the back of her head. "Besides, how do *you* know about what Hordak's doing?"

"Shadow Weaver told me."

Everything stops. A roaring fills her ears, but muted –a storm in the distance. "Shadow Weaver told you?" she repeats, voice thin. She turns to look back at Adora. "How exactly did *Shadow Weaver* tell you this?"

Something unreadable flits over Adora's face. "You didn't know?"

She's strangely detached as she feels herself take a few steps towards Adora and grab her by the collar. Her claws dig into the material, tearing it a little, but she's way too far gone to care. "*How*?"

The flicker is back in Adora's expression, but her gaze doesn't leave hers as she responds. "Catra… Shadow Weaver is in Bright Moon."

The roaring comes on in full force, and Catra lets go, recoiling like Adora's just hit her.

Honestly, she might as well have. Every piece of the goddamn puzzle falls into place, sharp edges cutting into her until she *bleeds*.

"Shadow Weaver left me for you," she says, and it sounds so *obvious*, like she should have known. "All of this happened because of *you*."

Adora protests, probably. Catra's not sure, because she can't hear her anymore. She can't hear *anything*, the roaring overwhelming, muting everything around her, plunging her in a daze. She walks away, unsure how she can still be standing when the ground's vanished under her feet.

It sounds obvious, because it *is.*

Of course it's Adora. How has she not figured this one out yet? It's *always* going to be Adora. No matter what Catra does, no matter what *Adora* does, this is how it always ends, how it will always end.

Adora gets chosen –Catra gets left behind.

Adora gets everything she's ever wanted –Catra gets *nothing*.

She bumps into Scorpia, but the woman's words don't reach her. Nothing is reaching her, right now, beyond the realization she's stuck in.

She grips the hilt of the sword hard enough for it to hurt and raises her head to stare at Scorpia.

In every scenario, as long as Adora is around, Catra will always *lose*.

"We are going back," she articulates, the syllables clipped, the sword shaking from how hard she's gripping it.

Well, not this time.

"We are going to open a portal."

This time, she is going to win.

"And we are going to crush them *all*."

Whatever it takes.

Five

Everything is falling apart.

Every panting breath burns as she runs through corridors, slipping on the metal on the sharpest turns but she doesn't slow down. There isn't *time*. Everything is falling apart, and if she lets it, it's going to come crashing on top of her and she is going to *lose*.

Again.

Adora is right.

The breath rushes out of her, her lungs *burn*, and she runs faster. No time, there's no *time*–

Entrapta's shout of pain. How horribly still she'd been on the floor. Scorpia's horrified face as she stared at the still crackling weapon.

As she stared at *Catra*.

No *time*.

She makes it to Hordak's sanctum. Everything is sparking, but it's all drowned out by the way the sword radiates light at the center of the room. "The princesses are here," she gasps out. "There's no time to waste, we need to *open* the *portal*."

Hordak doesn't reach for the switch like he needs to. "Where's Entrapta? I need her."

For one horrible second, her mind blanks.

No! I won't!

Put her on the transport for Beast Island!

No *time*!

Grasping every bit of the willpower she's been using to command an army for the past few months, she pulls herself together. It takes more effort than the army ever did.

She grins, laughs, and it's only a little bit hysterical. "Who do you think let the princesses in?"

She sees it on his face, every beat of it. For all his stature, all his pose as the great Horde leader, it's etched on every line. She'd recognize it anywhere.

Pure, unadulterated *betrayal*.

Jackpot.

"But she… she wouldn't."

Catra was lying, but she isn't when she replies: "Oh, you can't trust anyone. *Especially* a princess." She turns, and there's Adora, because she always *has* to be there, doesn't she?

Good. She can watch. "They'll just use you to get what they want."

Adora's eyes are fixed on her, wide, pleading, but Catra is *done*. "Open the portal," she says, turning back to Hordak, "and let's *end* this."

Voices echo –they're here. If they don't move now, Catra is going to lose *everything*. "Forget about them, pull the switch!"

The blast hits her with no warning, searing magic projecting her into the air. She crashes into the hard metal floor, and lifts her head to find the Rebels advancing, *Shadow fucking Weaver* at the

head and it's *too much*. She is not going to lose, and she certainly is not going to lose to *her*.

All Hordak has to do is pull the switch, but arrows fly towards him and he can't even manage that much. Instead, his useless defense starts the room crumbling, magic blasts mingling with the flares of pure energy the sword occasionally sends flying. Green tanks explode, the walls come collapsing down and Catra dives through the falling rubble, through the smoke and debris.

She barely even sees any of it. Only one thing matters right now.

And suddenly, the switch is right there. Within reach.

Like in a dream, she holds out a hand.

"Catra, please, don't!"

There's no time, but she pauses anyway. Looks over her shoulder.

She sees Adora, and it clicks.

Catra's won.

Her smile is genuine, this time. She's *won*. Who cares what happens now?

Catra pulls the switch, and the sword *burns* –and the world with it.

+1

Adora wakes up alone.

Which is… fine. Really, it is. Up until a couple of weeks ago, it was the norm, after all. So yeah. Totally fine.

The only thing is, during said couple of weeks, well… She's kind of gotten used to *not* doing that.

It's funny, really, because she'd thought she'd *never* get used to it. After everything, after all the pain, and hurt, and anger… The idea that she could just wake up, and Catra would be *there*, sleepily clinging to her, or mock glaring at her through sleep-heavy eyelids felt… impossible. The warmth it created every time it happened, the relief –she'd honestly thought she'd never get used to something as crazy as that.

But apparently, she did, at least a little, because she wakes to a cold, empty bed, and she doesn't *like* it.

Then again, she didn't *go to sleep* alone. Sure, it's only mid-afternoon –or early evening, she amends after a glance at the reddening sky through the window, *whoops*, she slept longer than planned–, so maybe Catra had other things to do, but *she*'s the one who insisted Adora take a nap in the first place. Actually, she'd more or less gently bullied her into it after Adora had gotten back to Bright Moon, a bit after noon.

It'd been another morning dedicated to clearing the roads to reestablish the supply routes between the villages of the Whispering Woods. The released plant life might have been a sign of Etheria shaking off centuries of restraints from the First Ones, but it had also had the unfortunate side effect of isolating a few areas. It'd trapped debris from Prime's armies into place, blocking the roads and making them impassable.

And so, while each princess supervised reconstruction efforts in their own kingdoms and worked together so that it'd go as smoothly as possible, Adora had been helping out between places. As it happened, turning into an eight-foot-tall warrior princess wasn't *just* good to overthrow evil alien dictators –it was also pretty useful when it came to lifting heavy debris out of the way.

Actually, she'd still been She-Ra when she'd stopped by Bright Moon. She'd only meant to drop by for a few minutes, with a couple of questions for Glimmer about which routes to prioritize, but, well. The roads weren't the *only* blocked out places. Soon enough, at the request of a few people, she was helping to clear

out the flowering vines obscuring a few of the higher windows and mosaics.

That was about when Catra had turned a corner. She'd taken one look at Adora, still She-Ra, sword outstretched to cut through a particularly stubborn branch, before marching over. She'd grabbed her wrist and dragged her behind her to their bedroom, with a mumble Adora hadn't *quite* been able to make out but that had sounded an awful lot like "get some fucking rest for once".

Adora *had* protested. Because, like, okay, so *maybe* she'd been a bit tired –maybe more than she'd realized, if she'd really slept until *sunset*– but still. After all, it made sense: even after everything, being She-Ra still took a lot out of her.

But she hadn't been *exhausted* or anything. She could have easily waited until the evening to sleep.

All this she'd said without changing back. That was mostly to show Catra she wasn't *as* tired as she clearly thought her to be, if she could hold the form. And if it let Adora tower over her a bit, well, that was just a coincidence.

The point is, she'd been planning on going back out, certain that Catra couldn't convince her she was tired enough to take a break. And, technically, she'd been right.

What *had* made her relent, and let Catra take her sword, then her tiara away, and eventually led to her changing back and crawling into bed, had nothing to do with how tired or not tired she was. No, all that was mostly down to Catra *also* crawling into bed, and then curling up on top of Adora, like her weight pinning her down would be the only thing that would get her to stay *still* and actually rest.

And okay, so maybe it's been two weeks, and maybe Adora's gotten used to this more than she thought, but she has not gotten used to it *enough* that she'd turn that down. Falling asleep with

Catra near her is a brand of calm she can't remember feeling in years –not since bunk beds in cold barracks, or maybe ever, really.

Yeah, falling asleep with Catra is *great*. Waking up with her? At least as great, if not more; that split second when she wakes up, before she remembers; the *rush*, when she does… *that* she'll never get used to.

Which is why Adora is *grumpy*.

And maybe a bit worried. She has no reason to be, she knows. But, well. It's been a tricky couple of years.

She gets out of bed, uselessly attempting to smooth down her wrinkled clothes. Once her hair is tied back into a messier approximation of her usual ponytail, she slips out into the Bright Moon halls.

The castle is mostly empty. It's late enough that the cleaning efforts have been paused for the day, and the few people she comes across are only vaguely familiar. The setting sun is streaming in through the tall windows, turning the very air golden, and glittering off the mosaics. A light, warm breeze ruffles the hairs she didn't catch with her elastic, and the smell of fresh flowers comes with it, peaceful to a fault.

She's starting to consider searching the kitchens –she'd found Bow and Glimmer there a few days ago, attempting baking after a series of long reconstruction-focused meetings had left Glimmer on the wrong side of frustrated– when a faint noise reaches her. It seems to come from the gardens ahead, and it sounds like… Shouts? She frowns when she registers the clink of metal, but relaxes when laughter comes a second later.

She follows the sound, and as she gets closer, the voices become clearer. Glimmer's, definitely; Netossa, shouting what could be encouragements; and the lower, familiar rasp of Catra's voice. Confused, she rounds the last corner, and emerges on top of the few steps that connect the castle to its gardens.

From here, she's directly facing the setting sun, and she has to blink against the sudden bright light. It takes a second for her vision to clear, and when it does, a few things click into place.

All the members of the Alliance, save Mermista and Seahawk, who have more extensive reconstruction to put together, are scattered in the garden, chatting and laughing. Bow is sitting with his back to a fountain as he fiddles with his tracker pad and a few tools, occasionally lifting his head to yell an encouragement. Near him, Melog's lounging in the grass, apparently enjoying a nap in the late evening sun. A bit further out, Perfuma and Scorpia are talking, sitting cross-legged in the grass, oblivious to what's happening. Close by, Netossa is sitting with her wife's head in her lap, clearly riveted by what she's looking at, while Spinnerella watches her with a fond, indulgent smile. Frosta is with them, but standing, and jumping into place with excitement as she stares at the spectacle.

And spectacle is definitely a good word for it; in the center of the garden stand Catra and Glimmer, circling each other. Glimmer, who is holding on to what seems to be a training sword, is tossing magic blasts in Catra's direction while she dodges. Said dodges are accompanied by dry, unimpressed commentary on Catra's part, and encouragements and occasional heckling from the sidelines.

It clicks: Catra and Glimmer are *sparring*. It's noteworthy, for sure, but…

None of that really registers with Adora, beyond a very basic level. Not once her gaze lands on Catra.

Catra, who is *grinning* as she taunts Glimmer about her aim, light on her feet as she jumps out of the way of Glimmer's attacks. She adds an extra flourish here and there, with the sole purpose, Adora's pretty sure, of annoying her adversary.

Catra, who is wielding a long, glittering sword.

Adora's sword.

So maybe it takes Adora an embarrassingly long time to stop staring. Honestly, it seems only fair.

She watches silently for a bit, trying –and failing– to pick her jaw up off the floor. Catra was never really one for weapons, even back in the Horde. It's not like she *needed* them, what with the whole claw situation. But that doesn't mean she doesn't know how to handle them.

And *boy* does she know how to handle them.

The Horde favored the quarterstaff, but every cadet was trained in a wide array of weaponry, including traditional things like swords. Adora doubts Catra kept up with that training during the war, but she clearly didn't forget it either: her movements are precise and strong as she defends herself. Adora swallows hard as she watches her flip the sword into the air, catching the hilt at a new angle and *slashing*, effectively cleaving one of Glimmer's blasts in half. She didn't even know her sword could *do* that.

She has no idea how long she stands there, mesmerized, but eventually, a blast comes a bit closer, sending Catra jumping back with a shriek Adora knows she'll never admit to. Reflexively, Adora breathes in, sharp. It's not loud, but Catra looks up instantly.

For one second, Adora sees her own *this-can't-be-real*, *how-did-i-get-so-lucky*, near *awe* reflected back at her, before the expression melts into a smug, amused look.

"*I'm not tired, Catra*," Catra says, high-pitched and sarcastic. She puts her free hand on her hip and uses the other to lift the sword and rest the flat of the blade on her shoulder, and Adora maybe gapes a little, it's fine. "*I don't need to rest. I'm just going to fall asleep in less than a minute and then sleep for* five hours."

Part of her admiration turns to annoyance. Because, well, yeah, okay, maybe that's a good point, but she's not going to *admit* to that, and Catra *certainly* doesn't need to look this smug about it.

And so, Adora crosses her arms, and starts down the steps as she calls out: "I can't believe you made me take a nap all so you could steal my sword."

Catra grins, impish and completely unapologetic, and Adora nearly misses a step, in time with the way her heart skips a beat. Catra lifts the sword again, twisting it this way and that and admiring the way the sunlight glints off of it –Adora's just admiring her, at this point.

"Sparkles wanted a sparring partner before she accidentally murdered someone during a meeting, and you were dead to the world." She swings the blade around a few more times. "And that thing was just *lying* there."

She throws it into the air, snatching the hilt out after a few spins – she's now *clearly* showing off, but Adora honestly doesn't mind in the slightest.

Catra's smile softens into something that's more fondly amused than smug and she shakes her head to herself before speaking again: "This one's nicer than your older one. Lighter. Easier to maneuver."

That's true –the sword always felt *right* in her hand, but the one the First Ones created always had a weight to it, like it was made for someone that had *just* a little bit more strength than she did. The one she has now has never made her feel like that. She starts agreeing before pausing, puzzled.

How would Catra know that, though? The original sword broke long before they started their trip into outer space…

It clicks in her head at the exact same time the realization seems to hit Catra; Adora sees her freeze just as her own mouth drops open a little. Unbidden, flashes of the times Catra had wielded Adora's former sword come to mind; all the taunts, the hurt, the injuries, the *mistakes*. Distantly, Adora sees Melog's coloring move

to a deeper, almost grey blue as they stand, but she can't look away from Catra, or from the clear *regret* on her face.

Adora takes a step forward, but doesn't get much further than that; there's a rush of pink, and Glimmer materializes right behind Catra. With a sweep of the training sword she'd so far mostly used decoratively, she sweeps the girl's legs out from under her, sending Catra tumbling down with a surprised yell.

Glimmer grins, a touch smug. "I win."

Catra gapes at her, pushing herself to a seated position, even as whoops, cheers, and cries of protests erupt from the sidelines. "That's *cheating*!"

Glimmer only shrugs. "Should have stayed focused instead of flirting."

Catra sputters angrily, but when Glimmer offers her a hand to stand, she takes it. She continues protesting the victory as she brushes herself off, but she's also smiling, and the pressure in Adora's chest releases a little. This will take time, but they *have* it, now. They will be okay.

Glimmer bounds back to Bow, who lifts his head and grins softly as she launches into what seems to be a dramatic reenactment of the spar, much to Frosta's delight.

Adora bites back a laugh at Catra's sour expression and crosses the distance between them to put an arm around her shoulders. She can't hold back her smile when Catra melts into her side, though.

"Better luck next time," she says, teasing, and snorts when Catra shoots her a murderous glare, planting the tip of the sword into the grassy ground.

Speaking of. She holds out a hand, one eyebrow lifting.

Catra only stares blankly at her, so she elaborates: "Well?" She tilts her head towards the sword. "It's still mine."

A flash of *something* passes in Catra's mismatched eyes, and the way it sends Adora's heart rate quickening is almost enough to make up for how cold she feels when she slips away.

"This?" she asks, and the flash is in her voice too, now, and it's *familiar*. "Oh, no, I don't think so. If you want it back, you're gonna have to *win* it back."

Adora's eyebrows fly up. Is she really–

Catra's smile quirks up a notch, showing a glimpse of fangs, and *yeah*, she really is. The flash finally has a name. It's a *challenge*.

She tilts her head, leaning forward over the sword that's still planted into the ground. "What's wrong, princess? Scared you'll lose without your magic sword? Don't blame you."

There's a few *oooh* floating up from where the others are hanging out, and Adora's mind is already made up. She reaches up to tighten her ponytail, and slips off her jacket, tossing it off to the side. She nods to Glimmer, who throws her training sword in her direction with an incredulous expression.

Adora snatches it out of the air and tries a few experimental swings. It's not perfect but it'll do. "I'm sorry, do you not remember how I spent years winning *before* I got that sword? I do not need it to kick your ass, thank you very much."

Catra's answering grin means only one thing –*prove it*.

Adora's more than happy to oblige.

To the sound of more whooping, they get into position, a few feet away from each other at the center of the garden. From the sound of it, bets are being placed, and Adora can't help a smug grin when she hears Netossa call her allegiance to her.

Said smug grin does take a bit of a hit when Glimmer, who's standing on the edge of the field with her hands on her hips, eyes her critically before loudly declaring: "Yeah, my money's on Catra."

Catra's laughter almost drowns out Adora's offended protest. "*What*?"

Glimmer just shakes her head. "You keep *staring*, Adora."

"I do *not*–" She's interrupted when Catra flies forward, sword at the ready. It's all she can do to take a step back and bring her own sword up to block.

She tosses Catra an incredulous look. "Cheat much?"

"Thought we were sparring, not *chatting*," is Catra's response, and on that, it is *on*.

This isn't what they trained with, but it doesn't matter; they have a rhythm, and it's barely seconds before they settle back into it. It's a dance they know well, after a childhood spent practicing it together. For the last two years, that was a problem: fighting Catra *hurt*. Not only because she knew where Adora would go and knew how to throw her off, but mostly because that familiarity was still there, with none of the warmth.

But this? This is more than warm, blazing while Adora grins as she blocks and parries and lunges forward. She's almost *dizzy* with it, the fact that she gets to have this, the exhilaration of facing Catra, with none of the hurt and anger that's come to be associated with it.

Catra drops low, and aims a sharp, precise swing below Adora's guard, sending her flying back and almost stumbling. Okay, so the hurt and anger might have gone, but the skill is definitely still there.

She refocuses –or tries to. It just happens to be somewhat *difficult*, when Catra uses the sword of protection like it's an extension of her own arm. Her eyes are bright with laughter as

she leads attack after attack, easily parrying Adora's own sword in a clash of metal, and okay, so *maybe* Glimmer was onto something with the staring thing.

Still –she's holding her own. Or at least, she is until Catra's smirk gets an extra smug edge. "Alright there, Adora? You seem distracted."

She *is*, but Catra doesn't need to know that. She narrows her eyes, the familiar warmth of competition making her stand straighter. "Doesn't sound like me."

"Oh yeah?" The glint in Catra's eyes is downright *dangerous*, but it's too late. She drops her guard and takes a sudden step forward, ending up right in Adora's personal space. Eyes widening, Adora hesitates mid step back, and it's all Catra needs.

In a second, the glittering blade of the sword is back in Adora's face. She lifts her own to block, but Catra twists her wrist, and suddenly, Adora's clashing the thin, fragile end of her blade with the stronger base of Catra's. The leverage gives her enough of an edge that she sends Adora taking a stumbling step back.

It'd be fine, except her foot catches on the uneven ground and suddenly she's down, her back against the grass, arm straining as she holds up her sword to keep Catra at bay. Glimmer *whoops* in the distance and Adora grits her teeth.

Catra's smug grin has not budged. "Not too late to forfeit, princess."

As *if*.

Except… Except she *is* kind of done for, here. She angles her wrist to try and glide the contact point of the blades back to where it'll be a more even fight, but Catra anticipates the move, adjusting the pressure to counter. Adora's got seconds before her last line of defense gets parried away, and Catra *knows* it.

She's won. With *Adora*'s sword.

Adora’s sword.

It clicks, and Adora grins. There’s a flash of wariness that momentarily cuts through Catra’s smug expression, but too late.

Adora’s sword, that responds to her commands. That she can materialize at will.

Or, you know. *De*materialize.

With more focus than Adora’s pretty sure she ever demonstrated in her entire time training with Light Hope, she lets the pull of She-Ra’s magic flood her. Not enough to transform; just enough to feel the sword as part of herself.

And feel it she does –every individual particle that makes up the sword, tingling at the edge of her awareness.

For half a second, she pulls those particles away from each other.

Catra’s eyes widen as Adora’s training sword goes *through* her temporarily half-dematerialized weapon of choice. Her balance completely shot, she stumbles forward, almost crashing onto Adora, who takes the opportunity to flip them over, until Catra’s the one with her back to the grass, Adora straddled over her and the flat of Adora’s blade gently pressed against her collarbone.

“You were saying?” Adora asks, with the most shit-eating, smug grin she can muster –it’s not exactly difficult.

There’s clapping in the distance, as well as complaints about *cheating*, and she looks up to grin brightly and wave in the direction of Netossa, who’s celebrating her victory the loudest.

She looks back down, expecting protests and fully prepared to rub her victory in Catra’s face as much as possible, but she’s caught off-guard by how *soft* the look in Catra’s eyes is, instead.

Catra's tone is deceptively casual when she speaks: “Looks like it’s a tie, then.”

Her words break through Adora's daze and she scoffs. "A tie?" she repeats, incredulous. "I'm pretty sure this"–she puts a bit more pressure on the training sword she's still holding into place–"means that I win."

An unconvinced *eh* sounds answers her, together with a smile so fond Adora's sure Catra's unaware of it. "I don't know. This doesn't feel like losing to me."

And Adora's going to protest, really, she is, except that when Catra reaches up to grab her collar and pull her in for a kiss, well…

She finds she can't help but agree.

End Notes

me realizing the +1 sequence is approx as long as the 5 others put together:
look, adora just has a lot to say, and all of it is about how amazing her gf is; who am I to stop her?

I got this idea while I was plotting chap 5 of bridges, and it wouldn't leave me alone until I wrote it. The fact that it gave me an excuse to rewatch some of my fave eps is completely coincidental. I hope you enjoyed, and I'd love to hear what you thought! 💕

Also, I have finally caved and made a she-ra sideblog, so if you'd like to chat about these characters, the show, or just swords in general, come find me at @ariesnoctua! In case you couldn't tell, I have A Lot to say about all these topics

Thanks for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!